

Do IMs Kill Productivity?

Business decisions facilitator or an idle chat tool? The two sides of instant messaging

“Yes, they encourage idle chat”

Asha Ayare

Head, Business Solutions, Kotak Mahindra Primus

Kotak Mahindra Primus has a partnership with Ford Motors, Australia, of which Kotak owns 40 per cent. The head office uses 150 PCs; 400 more are used in the branches. We want to optimise the time we give our employees with those PCs. We observed that employees chatted on instant messengers during working hours.

We could not monitor everyone's PCs. Adding to that was the bother of viruses and spyware through instant messengers, since every messenger today has a file transfer feature.

So, we formulated a business policy a year ago that permits only the use of business-oriented applications such as Microsoft Office. Messengers were uninstalled in all areas of the office, except the Treasury and Wholesale departments, who continue to use it for business purposes. Early morning reminders are sent via the instant messenger, and that's that.

This policy has eliminated idle chat, resulting in substantial productivity enhancement. News and other useful features offered by certain messenger applications help keep an individual updated, but then you have news Web sites for those updates, right?

“No, they are powerful office tools”

Nishant Kolgaonkar

Head, HR & GIAS, Computer Associates India Pvt Ltd

At CA, we see instant messaging as a powerful, real-time, shared communication tool. Instant messaging fosters rapid communication and decision-making, and provides people in an organisation a valuable way to introduce each other.

CA employees make active use of MSN Instant Messenger for internal communication. Our Human Resources department finds it a great way to keep in touch with, and improve relations with, employees. Teams scattered at multiple locations use it to coordinate their work, thus bringing about a noticeable surge in productivity.

At present, IMs are only used for internal communication. This effectively secures us from hacker attacks. We also use e-Trust, and that precludes hacker intrusions.

Chat messages here are short and concise, and hence, they do not really clog the bandwidth. CA employs a mature set of people who have free and on-demand access to different forms of communication such as telephone, fax, e-mail, etc. As such, IM is not a medium that somebody would exploit for idle talk. That has never been our concern.

— As told to Garfield D'Souza

